

MASKING & BURNOUT

Masking is the work an Autistic person does to look like they are coping — holding still, forcing eye contact, scripting the conversation, swallowing the overload. It runs at the stress level of a job interview, for hours, every day. Autistic burnout is what arrives when it has run too long: chronic exhaustion, loss of skills, and a collapsing tolerance for noise, light and people.

GRADES MEASURE OUTPUT. ACCESS IS ABOUT COST.

THE CLASSROOM SEES THE BEST HOURS · THE FAMILY GETS THE BILL

1 · THE MASK

Suppressing yourself to avoid consequences is not politeness and it is not maturity. It is threat management, and it spends the same energy the child needs in order to learn. It is also built to be invisible. Someone observing a well-masked child is watching the mask work.

2 · THE DEBT

The cost comes due after school. Meltdown, shutdown, sleep, tears, no words left. That is the school day arriving late. Home is not a second opinion about the same child — it is the two thirds of their day that nobody at school observes.

3 · THE COLLAPSE

Eventually there is nothing left to spend. Skills go. Sensory tolerance goes. School access goes, sometimes for months. Then the file is read back — good grades, no concerns — and the record of coping becomes the reason no help arrived.

A child who meets every expectation at school and cannot get off the couch at home is not fine. The collapse is data. So is the parent reporting it.

“A state of pervasive exhaustion, loss of function, increase in autistic traits, and withdrawal from life that results from continuously expending more resources than one has coping with activities and environments ill-suited to one’s abilities and needs.”

DORA RAYMAKER · DEFINING AUTISTIC BURNOUT · AUTISM IN ADULthood, 2020

SAY THIS IN THE ROOM

- **“At grade level” does not answer the question.**
Grade level is the output. We are asking what it costs to produce.
- **The current plan did not prevent the loss of school access.** Give the dates. A plan that has already failed once is evidence it is not sufficient.
- **Observation cannot rule out need.** A sweet, cooperative, engaged child and a child in serious distress are not alternatives.
- **Educational performance is not only academic.**
Attendance, mental health, communication, self-care and being able to enter the building all count.
- **Prior burnout is history, not a worry.** Ask what happened, when it happened, and how long recovery took.

ASK THIS IN THE ROOM

- ✓ what data does this refusal rest on, in writing?
- ✓ who observed, when, and for how long?
- ✓ what did you ask about the hours after school?
- ✓ how is this consistent with 34 CFR 300.111(c)(1)?
- ✓ what would have to happen before you evaluate?
- ✓ may we have the refusal, our procedural safeguards, and the meeting record?

Put the burnout history in writing, with dates. **“Could not get off the couch for six weeks” beats “struggled”.**

UNITED STATES · THE IDEA REGULATIONS ALREADY SAY THIS

Child find covers children who are passing. Schools must identify and evaluate children “who are suspected of being a child with a disability ... and in need of special education, **even though they are advancing from grade to grade.**” — 34 CFR 300.111(c)(1)

So does the right to a free appropriate public education. FAPE is owed to any child who needs it “even though the child has not failed or been retained in a course or grade, and **is advancing from grade to grade.**” — 34 CFR 300.101(c)(1)
Passing is not a lawful basis for declining to evaluate. The regulations name that exact situation and say the duty stands. *US federal law, not legal advice.*

“If you try and push for just one more day of school, then it is likely at some point, their capacity for being able to manage will burst.”

HELEN EDGAR · SUPPORTING PUPILS THROUGH AUTISTIC BURNOUT · AUTISTIC REALMS

Support is owed when the cost is discovered — not when the child can no longer pay it. **Do not make a child prove need by breaking.**

Adapted from the *Masking and Burnout* Why Sheet at stimpunks.org/why/masking-and-burnout, which carries the full detail and every source. Burnout is defined here from **Raymaker et al. (2020)**, *Autism in Adulthood*, and **Arnold, Higgins et al. (2023)**, ‘Confirming the nature of autistic burnout’, *Autism* 27(7). Camouflaging is linked to poorer mental health by **Hull et al. (2019)** and **Cage & Troxell-Whitman (2019)**. The school-facing material draws on **Helen Edgar**, ‘Supporting pupils through Autistic Burnout’ (Autistic Realms), quoted and used with her permission — her words remain hers and sit outside the CC0 grant below.